

Agile Leadership Foundations

Welcome!

Welcome to the **Agile Leadership Foundations** online self-learning course. We hope this course will generate plenty of valuable learning.

This course is designed to help you understand what the core elements of agile leadership are and what to focus on to help your teams and organization to thrive in the current fast changing world. Upon completing this course, you will be able to:

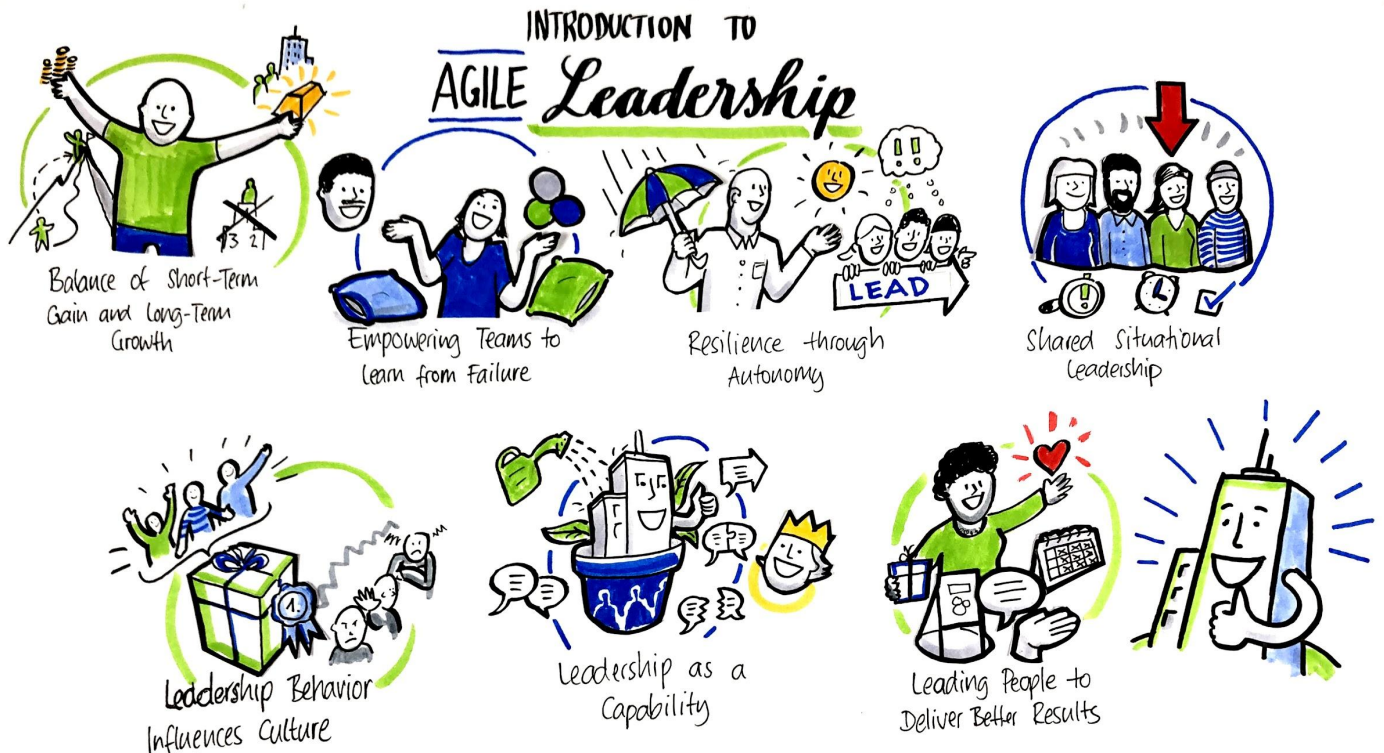
- List at least three key elements of agile leadership
- Identify at least two focus areas for an agile leader
- Define what is necessary to create a more agile and resilient organization
- Recognize at least six virtues of servant leadership
- Express at least three behaviors to practice a servant leadership approach
- Explain at least three skills of emotional intelligence
- Describe at least two tools to increase emotional intelligence

If you have any questions, please do not hesitate to contact us at education@agile42.com.

Introduction

In our fast-changing modern world, building and maintaining a thriving organization is a huge challenge, no matter the company's size. While it has always been necessary for managers and leaders to understand the business itself very well, today there are additional challenges. Organizations need to be adaptable, innovative, and engaging for people. In order to be successful in the new environment, a leader not only needs to learn a lot, but unlearn old paradigms that could be holding them back. To nurture successful teams and organizations, new and different behaviors, skills and tools are needed. This is where agile leadership can make a meaningful impact.

Introduction to Agile Leadership



Good Leadership is a Balance of Short-Term Gain and Long-Term Growth

First of all, agile leadership is nothing other than good leadership. In fact, if we consider agile leadership as a capability instead of a position or role, we are talking about keeping the right balance between focussing on the short-term gain and helping people overcome impediments which may slow down their progress, and, at the same time, nurturing and focussing on the long-term growth of individuals and the organization.

Empowering Teams to Learn from Failure

As agile leaders, we always need to think about how we can help people solve the problems that are blocking them, quickly. People talk about empowerment a lot. But empowerment is nothing else than delegating a certain amount of responsibility within certain boundaries, so that we know that people within these boundaries will operate in what we call a safe-to-fail way. It is our responsibility to create these safe-to-fail environments in which people can try and fail in making decisions, and their failure won't have any catastrophic consequences to the organization. If we are able to do that, we will help nurture a culture that will surely help our organization become more resilient and more agile in the future.

Resilience through Autonomy

Resilience is the capability of organizations to adapt more quickly to changes and recover faster from failure. This can only be achieved by increasing the level of autonomy within the organization, as much as, increasing the cognitive diversity. We don't want people to align behind structures, but we want them to experience things and form a common set of beliefs which will allow them to autonomously decide and

possibly move in a common direction in areas of very high uncertainty and instability within the organization. Depending on the level of autonomy of the work group, there might be situations in which even leadership becomes a shared responsibility. Self-organization, which is key in order to have agile teams successfully and effectively deliver value, requires a type of floating leadership within a group that shares the responsibility.

Shared Situational Leadership

Shared leadership, or rather the shared responsibility of leadership, allows an individual to take on the role of a leader in a specific moment of time based on the level of trust they have been able to gain within their own team. In fact, knowing the situation and understanding what are the most appropriate behaviors in a given situation will probably create the most positive cultural impact, which is the art of being a good agile leader.

Leadership Behavior Influences Culture

If we demonstrate a behavior that has a positive impact on the people around us, we will actually create more engagement and motivation. This will increase the sense of ownership and the commitment in delivering high value and good results. On the other hand, if we demonstrate behavior that causes a negative impact, people will start to disconnect, push back and feel strange about the proposed way of coordinating work. Since this is different from what they would naturally expect, we might even be increasing the negative impact.

Leadership as a Capability

So, we can say that agile leadership should be more of an organizational capability which needs to be nurtured over time, instead of a speciality that only a few people need to have within an organization. Leadership, as a capability, requires us to learn how to lead and develop the necessary skills. Not only interpersonal communication skills, but also learning things like conflict resolution, collaborative decision making or constructive feedback. These are going to be very useful in an organization in which people need to collaborate with one another and deliver value to the client.

Leading People to Deliver Better Results

Ultimately, agile leadership is about enabling people to work and deliver results and in doing so, have fun at work and develop a sense of ownership. This requires us to continuously coach, mentor, support and facilitate the work these people do every day and, in doing, so we create experiences which help them grow in the direction we want -- helping them to establish the values and beliefs which will then guide them to make decisions even in conditions of uncertainty. Taking together, this will allow our organization to become more resilient and more agile, and deliver better results to the market.

Servant Leadership

The future of work has arrived faster than we could have imagined in our post-pandemic world. One of the defining characteristics of this modern workplace is a shift away from traditional decision-making hierarchies. In today's workplace, it makes more sense for decisions to be made by those individuals closest to the problem at hand. Teams are self-managed, meaning they decide what to work on, when to work on it, and how to best achieve the desired outcome. This shift comes with new demands on leadership, and effective leaders cultivate the values of servant leadership.

Expectations on leaders have shifted along with these changes. The very best leaders are not telling anyone what to do. Instead, they are removing impediments, aligning stakeholders, building relationships, coaching, providing feedback, developing people's skills and growing the capabilities of the organization. They create the conditions for individuals and teams to perform at their best.

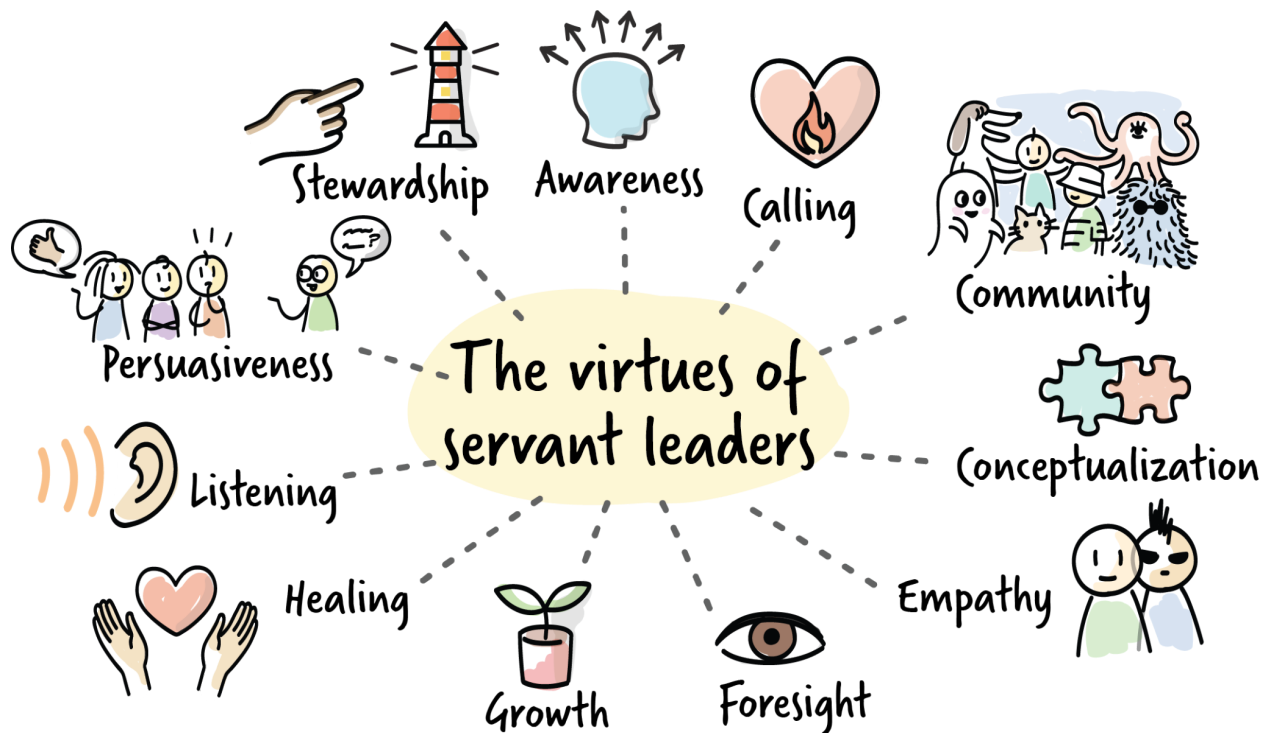
What is Servant Leadership?

Servant leadership is a leadership philosophy and a set of practices in which the leader puts the needs of the employees first and helps people develop themselves and excel. Robert K. Greenleaf first popularized the term servant leadership in *The Servant as Leader*, an essay published in 1970.

The term might sound like an oxymoron the first time you hear it. You may think that the teams are there to serve the leaders, but in fact, organizations can benefit more when things are the other way around. A servant leader should be asking themselves: Do my actions help those I lead grow as individuals? Do they, because of my actions, become healthier, wiser, freer, more autonomous, more likely to become leaders themselves?

The Virtues of Servant Leaders

According to Greenleaf, servant leaders cultivate eleven key virtues. These virtues are maybe even more essential now than they were in 1970. In the current world, leaders can't be effective without trust from people they are supposed to lead, and these virtues ultimately build trust.



Awareness

They have a keen sense for what is happening around them. They know what's going on and will rarely be fooled by appearances.

Calling

They are willing to sacrifice egocentric interests for the benefit of others. They have a natural calling to serve, which cannot be taught.

Community

They believe that an organization needs to function as a community. They instill a spirit of community in the workplace.

Conceptualization

They have the ability to conceptualize the world, events and possibilities. They encourage others to dream great dreams and avoid getting bogged down by day-to-day realities and operations.

Empathy

They understand and empathize with others' circumstances and problems.

Foresight

They are able to anticipate future events. They are adept at picking up patterns in the environment and seeing what the future will bring. They can anticipate consequences of decisions with great accuracy.

Growth

They believe that all people have something to offer beyond their tangible contributions. They work hard to help people in a number of ways.

Healing

They have appreciation for the emotional health and spirit of others. They are good at facilitating a healing process of relationships, when necessary.

Listening

They are receptive and genuinely interested in the views and input of others.

Persuasiveness

They are able to convince others to do things, rather than relying on formal authority. They never force others to do things.

Stewardship

They show a desire to prepare the organization to contribute to the greater good of society, making a positive difference in the future.

How to Build Trust as a Servant Leader

One of the most effective ways to build trust is to demonstrate that you truly care about people and you are committed to their growth. Most people want to feel they are valued as individuals; that they are heard and not judged. Ultimately, it is about making the workplace more humane and fit for human beings. Servant leadership is necessary to build leadership as a diffused organizational capability, or in other words, to make everyone a potential leader.

The Challenges of Servant Leadership

It is really difficult for managers who have learned all they know in a traditional environment to change their fundamental leadership beliefs. They might be scared to let things go, or insecure because they don't yet know how to contribute in a new and different way. They might be afraid to become useless or redundant, and they might feel lost since they might have never seen a real example of servant leadership themselves. A lot of the feedback they receive is what not to do, but there aren't always great resources to help them discover what to do. Finally, managers might be so used to pushing their ideas and instructions onto their teams, that they end up pushing and forcing these new ideas too fast, with the unintended consequence of frustration and dissatisfaction of the people involved.

How to Practice a Servant Leadership Approach

The following behaviors can help leaders understand and practice a servant leadership approach:

- Listen to your own fears with compassion and get support from a coach or a peer in trying different behavioral patterns, one at a time
- Visualize the benefits of applying those behavioral patterns, for example asking for feedback through storytelling
- Build mutual trust between management and teams for instance by being present where the work happens and practicing MBWAL (Management By Walking Around and Listening) instead of MBSR (Management By Status Report)
- Encourage peer support and peer feedback among leaders - things are less difficult if done together

Emotional Intelligence in the Workplace

Practicing the virtues of servant leadership helps develop effective leadership in this fast-changing world. But what other qualities does an agile leader need to have?

If you want to become the kind of leader who masters multiple leadership behaviors and is able to read the situation and use an approach that is coherent to the context, you might want to develop your emotional intelligence.

Daniel Goleman was the first to popularize the idea of emotional intelligence and demonstrate evidence of its impact within organizations. He passionately argued for recognizing the relationship between someone's emotional state and the actions driven by it, and how those actions in turn impact others and the organization (essentially the people they work with), whether positively or negatively.

Emotional Intelligence Consists of Four Fundamental Skills

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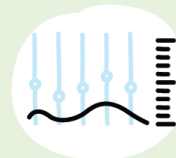
Self-awareness

Self-awareness is the ability to read and understand your own emotions as well as recognize their impact on work performance and relationships. It also includes the ability to realistically evaluate your strengths and limitations.



Self-management

Self-management is the ability to keep disruptive emotions and impulses under control, consistently display integrity and manage yourself and your responsibilities. It also includes the skill to adjust to changing situations and a readiness to seize opportunities.



Social awareness

Social awareness is the ability to sense other people's emotions, understand their perspective, and take an active interest in their concerns. It is also the ability to read the currents of organizational life, build decision networks, and navigate politics.



Social skills

These are the abilities to inspire, influence and develop others, de-escalate conflicts and facilitate resolutions. These include skills of listening and sending clear, convincing, and well-tuned messages, as well as cultivating and maintaining a web of relationships.



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Emotional Intelligence in Leaders

These are all essential qualities for leaders, even though not everyone seems to realize it. Many organizations still use a fundamentally wrong metaphor to describe how work functions. We keep thinking of our organizations as machines, where defined inputs are transformed into defined outputs, through defined processes and well designed connections of cogs. Is this the real nature of our organizations? How can such a machine adapt to ever changing circumstances and market needs?

We will have better chances at building agile and flexible organizations, which are more equipped to succeed in the world today, if we start describing them as living organisms. Organizations are networks of people, and human beings are not interchangeable and programmable machines. It is impossible to force things on people, but good things can be achieved by leveraging people's natural talents and their intrinsic willingness to do a good job.

Effective leadership is more of a social activity than an engineering task.

How Do You Increase Your Emotional Intelligence?

Here are some simple tools for growing your emotional intelligence:

- Journaling is the practice of keeping record of personal thoughts, feelings, insights connected to certain events, through handwriting, typing or even drawing. Regular journaling helps strengthen self-awareness: it is useful to spot our triggers and understand their impact on work performance and relationships, as well as keep disruptive emotions under control
- Self-reflection helps conceptualize experience and learn how to apply successful patterns to similar contexts or dampen ineffective behaviors

- Peer feedback originates from trusted peers based on observations: it is a precious resource to address improvement areas which we are unable to become aware of by ourselves
- 360° feedback is feedback from many peers, leaders, and colleagues, rather than a single manager in a top-down approach. It can be very helpful to learn how to sense other peoples' emotions and understand their perspective.

Improving as an Agile Leader

A question on many agile leaders' minds is: How do we know how well we are doing as leaders? To be able to answer this question we could measure the impact that our leadership has on the autonomy of our team, the culture and the resilience of our organization. However, these are all lagging indicators which we can evaluate only in hindsight: sometimes leadership is like planting seeds of a tree we will never enjoy the shade of.

However, we could also look at a few leading indicators to understand whether we are going in the right direction and get feedback. In this way we will be able to improve by leveraging our strengths and acting on our improvement areas.

Leading Indicators for Effective Leadership

Servant Leadership

A first leading metric could be around how we are doing as servant leaders. When we demonstrate servant leadership, we are likely to be strengthening people's skills and building leadership as a diffused organizational capability, so that everyone can be a potential leader. A few questions can help us self-reflect on the different servant leadership virtues and their impact on the people around us:

- Do people believe that I am willing to sacrifice my own self-interest for the good of the group?
- Do people believe that I want to hear their ideas and will value them?
- Do people believe that I understand what is happening in their lives and how it affects them?
- Do people come to me when chips are down or when something traumatic has happened in their lives?
- Do others believe that I have a strong sense of awareness for what is going on?
- Do others follow my requests because they want to and not because they have to?
- Do others communicate their ideas and vision for the organization when I am around?
- Do others have confidence in my ability to anticipate the future and its consequences?
- Do others believe that I am preparing the organization to make a positive difference in the world?
- Do people believe that I am committed to helping them develop and grow?
- Do people feel a strong sense of community in the organization that I lead?

Once you identify your biggest strength and your biggest improvement area, meet with a peer and:

1. Share a story describing a situation where you demonstrated the servant leadership virtue you believe represents your biggest strength
2. Ask for a suggestion what to do tomorrow to become one inch better at practicing the virtue you feel you are struggling most with

Mastering Multiple Leadership Behaviors

Another useful leading indicator could be about our ability to master multiple leadership behaviors. If we are able to adopt the appropriate leadership behavior in each situation or context, we can reduce motivational debt and grow autonomy and resilience in the organization. A leadership behavior assessment can help us reflect and show us how to strengthen our leadership muscles.

Our leadership behavior assessment is based on SenseMaker® technology developed by Dave Snowden and The Cynefin Co. Both the leader and their followers capture and interpret situations in which the leader demonstrated a certain behavior. Multiple perspectives on the same situation help the leader realize how well they master different leadership behaviors and how coherently they apply those to different situations and contexts.

Continue Learning

Final Reflection

As it is the end of the course we would like you to take a minute and reflect on the following questions:

- What is your biggest take away from this course?
- Which tools or concepts would you apply in your context?
- How will you continue to improve - what are your next steps?

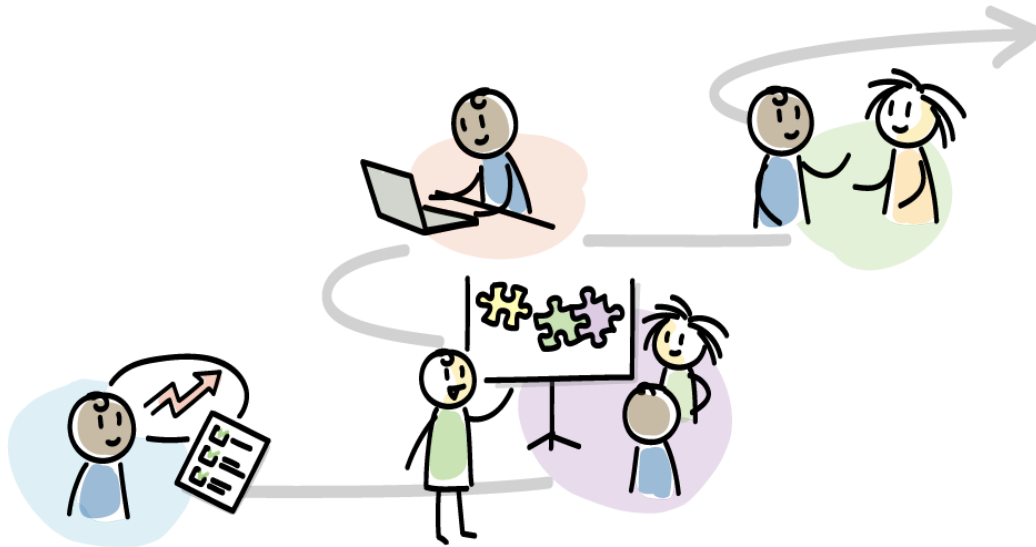
Additional Resources

In order for you to continue learning, we suggest the following resources:

- In the podcast [An agile leadership mindset](#) hosted by The Product Bakery Podcast, agile42 co-founder and coach Andrea Tomasini shares the challenges organizations face and what companies and leaders can do to better manage uncertainty. Understand what agile is really all about and how to develop and implement an agile mindset in your teams and company.
- In the webinar [Leadership in complex environments](#), agile42 coach Lasse Ziegler explores how an effective leader in the 21st century can adopt a multi-dimensional leadership approach and use the appropriate leadership behavior which fits the specific situation as well as creates the least motivational debt given the specific cultural context.
- In the webinar [Archetypes: mapping organization, culture and leadership](#), agile42 coach Giuseppe De Simone introduces the concept and gives an overview of organizational archetypes that are expressed under specific conditions. He also explores some methods within the ORGANIC agility framework, that allow you to recognize the archetype to which an organization can be mapped at a given moment in time, and provide guidance for increasing coherence between culture, organizational design and leadership behaviors.
- In the pamphlet [The Servant as Leader](#), author Robert K. Greenleaf describes some of the characteristics and activities of servant-leaders, providing examples which show that individual efforts, inspired by vision and a servant ethic, can make a substantial difference in the quality of society.
- In his book [Emotional Intelligence: Why it can matter more than IQ](#), psychologist Daniel Goleman, drawing on groundbreaking brain and behavioral research, shows the factors which determine why people of high IQ can fail at work and those of modest IQ can do extremely well.

Support for your personal development journey

Continue Your Agile Journey with Our Expert Coaching and Training.



You've completed your course and have gained valuable knowledge and skills in agility. But learning is a continuous process, and we're here and committed to support you on your personal development journey. Whether you're looking to improve your team's agile practices, advance your career, or deepen your knowledge and skills, our expert coaches and trainers are here to support you, and they offer personalized coaching and training to help you achieve your goals.

- Get personalized coaching and support tailored to your specific needs and goals
- Learn practical techniques and best practices from experienced agile professionals
- Deepen your knowledge and skills in agile methodologies and frameworks

Button: [Contact us](#)

You can also join our LinkedIn group - it's a safe and private group where you can connect with our coaches and other like-minded professionals. Request to join now and make sure you introduce yourself when you arrive.

Button: [Request access](#)

Quizzes

Introduction to Agile Leadership

Which of the following are key elements of agile leadership?

- Empowering teams to learn from failure
- Focusing on short term goals
- Increasing agility and resilience by growing autonomy
- Using the leadership behavior you feel most comfortable with
- Enabling people to deliver better results

Explanation: Agile leadership is about enabling people to work and deliver results and, by doing so, have fun at work and develop a sense of ownership. This requires the leader to continuously coach, mentor, support and facilitate the work and therefore create the right environment for people to learn and grow in the right direction. While increasing the level of autonomy and cognitive diversity in the team, an agile leader creates the experiences which can shape beliefs and nudge behaviors that are coherent with the agile values.

In an agile organization, leadership becomes...

- An obstacle to self-organization
- A role that experienced Agile Coaches can apply for
- A capability that has to be developed and nurtured
- Irrelevant because agile teams are autonomous

Explanation: Leadership in an agile context is an **organizational capability** which needs to be developed over time instead of a specialty which only a few people need to have. Leadership as a capability requires people to learn how to lead and develop the necessary skills, not only interpersonal communication, but also things like navigating conflicts, collaborative decision making or constructive feedback.

A leader in an agile organization focuses on...

- Fostering a healthy organizational culture
- Implementing solid processes and tools

- Defining clear roles and responsibilities
- Empowering teams to make good decisions
- All of the above

Explanation: If we demonstrate leadership behavior which has a positive impact on the people around, we will actually create more engagement and motivation. This will increase the sense of ownership and commitment in delivering high value and good results. An **agile leader** shifts their focus from managing tasks to creating a healthy organizational culture where individuals and teams grow and can make the right decisions.

Servant Leadership

Which of the following are virtues of servant leaders?

- Awareness, empathy, listening
- Visionary, engaging, entrepreneurship
- Calling, community, healing
- Clarity, assertive, structure

Explanation: Servant leadership is a leadership philosophy and a set of practices in which the leader puts the needs of the employees first and helps people develop themselves and excel. Robert K. Greenleaf, who first popularized the term in an essay published in 1970, explains that servant leaders cultivate eleven key virtues: **awareness, calling, community, conceptualization, empathy, foresight, growth, healing, listening, persuasiveness, stewardship.**

How can you build trust as a servant leader?

- Demonstrate your competence
- Provide the right answers to team members
- Show a clear direction and a sound plan
- Demonstrate that you truly care about people and their growth

Explanation: One of the most effective ways to build trust is to demonstrate that you truly care about people and you are committed to their growth. Most people want to feel they are valued as individuals; that they are heard and not judged. Ultimately, it is about making the workplace more humane and fit for human beings.

Which of the following are effective behaviors to practice a servant leadership approach?

- Asking a coach or peer for support to try different behavioral patterns
- Asking for feedback through storytelling to visualize the benefits of applying new behavioral patterns
- Encouraging peer support and peer feedback
- All of the above

Explanation: The following behaviors can help leaders understand and practice a servant leadership approach:

- Listen to your fears with compassion and ask a coach or peer for support to try different behavioral patterns, one at a time
- Visualize the benefits of applying those behavioral patterns, for example asking for feedback through storytelling
- Build mutual trust between management and teams for instance by being present where the work happens and practicing MBWAL (Management By Walking Around and Listening) instead of MBSR (Management By Status Report)
- Encourage peer support and peer feedback among leaders - things are less difficult if done together

Emotional Intelligence in the Workplace

Which of the following are skills of emotional intelligence?

- Social awareness
- Self-management
- Self-awareness
- All of the above

Explanation: According to Daniel Goleman, who popularized the idea of emotional intelligence and demonstrated evidence of its impact within organizations, emotional intelligence consists of four fundamental skills: **self-awareness, self-management, social awareness and social skills**.

Effective leadership is...

- A social activity
- An engineering task
- A part time job
- A formal role

Explanation: Organizations are networks of people, and human beings are not interchangeable and programmable machines. It is impossible to force things on people, but good things can be achieved by leveraging people's natural talents and their intrinsic willingness to do a good job. Effective leadership is more of a **social activity** than an engineering task.

Which of the following are tools to increase your emotional intelligence?

- Reading books
- Journaling
- 360° feedback
- Thorough planning

Explanation: **Journaling, self-reflection, peer feedback and 360° feedback** are simple tools for growing your emotional intelligence.